

Day 1 — Operational Signals & KPIs

Activity packet for participant triads. This file is the single source of truth for your small-group work, examples, and deliverable templates.

Where we are in the week

Week 2 opens by giving each triad a vocabulary for "what better looks like." Today's job is to install three terms that will be used every day for the rest of the academy: **operational signal**, **KPI**, and **North Star** (which gets its full treatment on Day 2).

Inputs from Week 1: each triad arrives with its **problem statement** and **Prompt Pattern Library**. Both are referenced today.

The Metrics Tier Sheet (today's main artifact)

Each triad ends Day 1 with a Metrics Tier Sheet for the FieldPulse problem they framed in Week 1. The sheet has three rows:

TIER	DEFINITION	HOW MANY TODAY	PURPOSE
North Star (NS)	The single metric that, if it goes up, the customer is winning AND the business is winning	1 candidate (placeholder)	Day 2 will replace this
KPI	Business-level outcome that the NS rolls up to or that signals NS health	2–3	Quarterly board view
Operational signal	Daily/hourly leading indicator a team can act on	4–6	What the squad watches in standups

A "well-formed" tier sheet has a believable **causal chain**: a change in an operational signal plausibly ripples up to a KPI, which ripples to the NS.

Activity 1 — "Metric or Vanity?"

Format: Triad • 35 min • Block 1

Purpose

Ground the room in the difference between metrics that move because the customer's life got better, and metrics that move because the team got clever.

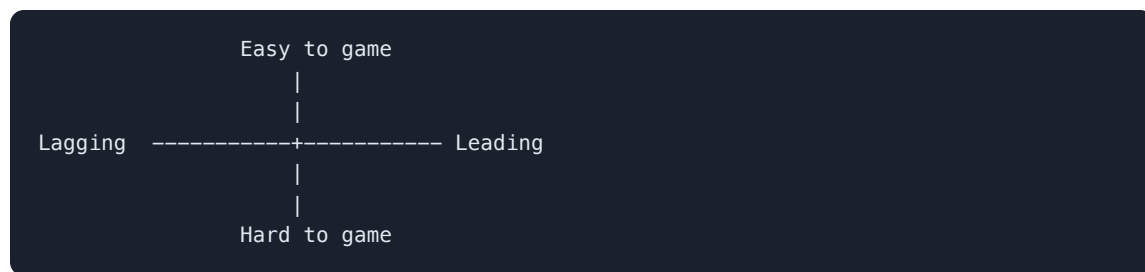
Setup

Each triad receives the **Vanity-Metric Card Pack** (12 metrics drawn from FieldPulse-adjacent SaaS products). Examples in the pack:

- Daily Active Users
- Number of features shipped per quarter
- Average session length
- % of dispatchers who completed onboarding
- Support tickets closed per agent per day
- Mean time to first dispatch after login
- Reconcile-flow completion rate
- New trial sign-ups per week

Steps

For each card, the triad places it on a 2x2:



Then they pick the **two cards** they would bet on for FieldPulse and the **two cards** they would never report up.

Deliverable

A sorted 2x2 with bet-on and never-report-up cards labeled, plus a one-sentence rationale per pick.

Readout (60 seconds per triad)

"We would bet on [X] and [Y] because [reason rooted in causal chain]. We would never report up [A] or [B] because [reason]."

Activity 2 — Operational signal sprint

Format: Triad • 40 min • Block 2

Purpose

Generate a credible bench of operational signals for the triad's Week-1 problem statement.

Setup

Each triad has its Week-1 problem statement pinned visibly. Each member needs sticky notes or a shared doc for solo brainstorm.

Steps

1. Re-read the triad's problem statement aloud.
2. Each triad member independently writes 4 candidate operational signals (12 total).

3. The triad culls to **6 finalists**. For each, capture:
- **What it measures**
 - **Where the data comes from** (system, log, instrumentation gap)
 - **How fast it moves** (real-time, hourly, daily, weekly)
 - **What action a team would take** if it dropped 30%

The "instrumentation gap" check

For at least 2 of the 6 finalists, the triad will discover the data **does not exist yet**. That is intentional. Mark these in red — they become input for the Week 4–5 technical infrastructure conversations.

Output (added to Metrics Tier Sheet)

The 6 operational signals populate the bottom row.

Deliverable

6 operational signals with what they measure, source, cadence, and action-if-dropped. At least 2 marked as instrumentation gaps.

Activity 3 — KPI laddering

Format: Triad • 40 min • Block 3

Purpose

Bridge from operational signals (squad-level) to KPIs (org-level). This is where TPMs earn their seat in cross-functional rooms.

Setup

Each triad has the 6 operational signals from Activity 2 visible.

Steps

The laddering exercise

Take the 6 operational signals from Activity 2. For each, the triad answers:

"If this signal moved 30% in the right direction for an entire quarter, what business KPI would that show up in?"

Cluster operational signals that ladder to the same KPI. Aim for **2–3 KPI clusters**.

KPI quality bar

A well-formed KPI for FieldPulse passes all four:

- ☐ Spoken in business terms (revenue, retention, time-to-value, NPS)
- ☐ A senior leader cares about it without translation
- ☐ You can imagine a single chart that shows it weekly
- ☐ You can name what's "good" without inventing a number

Output (added to Metrics Tier Sheet)

The 2–3 KPIs populate the middle row.

Deliverable

2–3 candidate KPIs added to the Tier Sheet, each passing the four-question KPI quality bar, with the operational signals that ladder into each one explicitly named.

Activity 4 — Tier Sheet defense + North Star placeholder

Format: Triad • 45 min + Readouts • Block 4

Purpose

Complete the Tier Sheet, do a peer-defense round, and seed Day 2's North Star work.

Setup

Pair each triad with another. Both triads have draft Tier Sheets (NS placeholder + KPIs + operational signals).

Steps

Triad workflow

1. **Draft a North Star placeholder** (15 min). The triad invents a one-sentence NS using the template:

"We are winning when [customer outcome] increases for [user segment], measured by [single number]." This will be revisited tomorrow. Today, just get a placeholder to react to.

2. **Pair-defense round** (20 min). Each triad pairs with another triad. Defender presents the Tier Sheet for 4 minutes. Challenger uses the **Three Standard Challenges**:
 - **Causal chain**: "Show me how a change in operational signal #3 plausibly moves your KPI."
 - **Gameability**: "Pick the easiest of these to game. How would a sales-incentivized team game it?"
 - **Instrumentation**: "Which two of these can you actually measure today, in production?"
3. **Refine** (10 min). Capture the strongest challenge in a "known weaknesses" line at the bottom of the Tier Sheet.

Readout structure (60 seconds per triad)

"Our NS placeholder is [X]. Our hardest challenge was [Y]. Our biggest instrumentation gap is [Z]."

Deliverable

A complete Metrics Tier Sheet (NS placeholder + KPIs + 6 operational signals) plus a "known weaknesses" line capturing the strongest challenge from the defense round.

End-of-day checkpoint

Each triad leaves the day with:

- ✓ A complete Metrics Tier Sheet (NS placeholder + 2–3 KPIs + 6 operational signals)
- ✓ At least one named instrumentation gap
- ✓ One "known weakness" of the current Tier Sheet (from the defense round)
- ✓ A Day 2 commitment: bring a candidate alternative to your NS placeholder